

Capacity Becomes Strategy

Edition 1 in the Belastingdienst series.

Cycle: 28 April 2026 · Audience: Senior strategy, execution, supervision and IV leadership · Horizon: 6 to 18 months primary, 2 to 5 years secondary

Read estimate: 4 min Executive Synthesis · 19 min full read



What you will learn

1. Why a postponed programme costs more than a cancelled one, and who pays for the difference
2. What happened when the one deadline that held arrived, and why the receipts went somewhere else
3. Which of this administration's dates are fixed in law and which are a negotiating position

Key takeaways

1. Three of the four deadlines that framed the July cycle moved; the fourth reshaped the trade it taxed
2. E-commerce customs declarations fell 46% and their item lines 70% in the two months after 1 July
3. The AI Act high-risk date moved to 2 December 2027, and none of the constraints that actually bind moved

Why This Matters Now

Five large programmes are queuing for the same scarce resource at the same time: the Box 3 transition, the new coalition's reform mandate, the European e-invoicing build, the rebuild of fraud defences, and compliance with the EU's AI rules. The resource is not money and it is not headcount. It is the capacity to change systems safely, and it is only now beginning to come free.

That makes capacity allocation the strategic decision of this cycle rather than a planning detail. Whichever of the five is served first is, in effect, the organisation's strategy, whether or not anyone writes it down that way. Around this sits a harder constraint still:

trust is recovering slowly, the ceiling on the administration's own use of AI is rising just as AI-enabled fraud scales, and the working environment for staff has hardened to the point where a court has allowed them to be named only by reference number.

The one thing to take into the next meeting: the queue will be resolved either by decision or by default, and a default is the most expensive option available.

Executive Synthesis

Which of the five programmes competing for your change capacity has actually been ranked, and by whom?

Box 3, the reform mandate, the e-invoicing build, the fraud-defence rebuild and AI Act compliance all draw on the same scarce capacity, and nothing in the public record ranks them against each other.

This is the first Decision Intelligence cycle on the Belastingdienst, so it sets a baseline rather than grading a previous reading. The baseline is this: capacity has stopped being a support question and become the strategic one. Five major workstreams are converging on the same constrained change capacity. The Box 3 transition is legislated toward 1 January 2028, with the Wet werkelijk rendement box 3 through the lower house in February ([Meijburg & Co](#), May 2025). The new coalition has committed to a fundamental overhaul of income tax, benefits and social security with its reform agenda due at the end of the year ([EY Netherlands](#), Feb 2026). The European e-invoicing and digital reporting build runs to a 2030 mandate ([RTC Suite](#), Oct 2025). Fraud defences need rebuilding against a materially different attacker. And the EU AI rules fall due inside the window.

Nothing in the public record ranks these five against one another. That is the finding. A queue that is never explicitly ordered is still ordered, by whichever programme has the nearest statutory date or the loudest sponsor, and the result is a strategy nobody chose. The lever available is prioritisation with disclosure: saying out loud which of the five is being served first and what the others will not get, rather than absorbing the conflict inside delivery plans where it becomes visible only as slippage.

Three constraints sit underneath and none of them is inside the organisation's gift. Trust is recovering, but slowly and from a low base: reported trust in government fell from 51% to 44% across a single winter, and among the most highly educated group,

historically the most positive, from 60% to 52% ([the Sociaal en Cultureel Planbureau](#), Mar 2025). The Algemene Rekenkamer found that the Belastingdienst and Dienst Toeslagen still do not manage privacy risks well in their use of algorithms, while pointing out that another executive agency runs the same class of tool compliantly ([the Algemene Rekenkamer](#), May 2025). And the working environment has hardened far enough that in January a court accepted that naming tax officials in cases involving the soevereinen movement would expose them to real danger ([the Gerechtshof Arnhem-Leeuwarden](#), Jan 2026).

A queue that is never explicitly ordered is still ordered, by whichever programme has the nearest statutory date or the loudest sponsor. That is a strategy nobody chose.

The cross-border wave is the cycle's clearest opportunity and its clearest squeeze, and it is the same wave. DAC8 took effect on 1 January 2026 and the Dutch implementing bill cleared the lower house in March ([KPMG](#), Mar 2026); the 2026 package carried DAC9 and the latest Pillar Two guidance ([KPMG](#), Dec 2025). Taken together these give the administration its strongest information position in a decade. They also arrive as one more set of overlapping reporting regimes on an administration that is already among the busiest recipients in Europe, which is the case the advisers' own recast submission makes ([CFE Tax Advisers Europe](#), Feb 2026). The uplift and the burden are not separable, and the second is not a reason to decline the first.

The temptation in a cycle like this is to treat the reform mandate as the answer to everything: a window in which the citizen-state interaction could be redesigned rather than merely maintained. The window is real. The capacity to use it is the thing this brief keeps returning to, and the administration's own published plan is more sober about it than the surrounding commentary. That tension is not resolved here. It is the fourth theme, and the evidence there runs against the optimistic reading.

Where this analysis could be wrong

The capacity crunch has been the standing narrative for years, and collection has not failed. An argument that this time the queue is different has to carry that history. The honest form of the claim is narrower: not that the organisation will fail, but that five programmes with external dates cannot all be first, and that the ranking is currently implicit. The thesis weakens if a published plan ranks them explicitly and names what each will not receive.

Three of this cycle's fraud sources are commercially interested and make the same argument. Sumsb, Experian and Sardine all sell fraud prevention and all argue that agentic AI fraud is arriving and that incumbent detection cannot stop it ([Sumsb](#), Nov 2025) ([Experian](#), Jan 2026) ([Sardine.ai](#), Feb 2026). That is one vendor argument repeated three times, not three independent corroborations, and two of the three are forecasts about 2026 written before it began. We have treated the direction as credible and the magnitude as unevidenced.

Parts of the evidence base are thinner than a source count suggests. The Algemene Rekenkamer news item and its underlying audit report are one publication, not two ([the Algemene Rekenkamer](#), May 2025) ([the Algemene Rekenkamer](#), May 2025), and the two Burgerperspectieven instalments are successive editions of one series ([the Sociaal en Cultureel Planbureau](#), Mar 2025) ([the Sociaal en Cultureel Planbureau](#), Oct 2025). Six of the pages cited carry no printed publication date at all, including the European Commission's own AI policy page, so they are recorded as undated rather than assigned a date inferred from a web address. The court ruling is cited from a commercial aggregator rather than the court's own text, which is why it is graded Tier 3 despite being a judgment ([the Gerechtshof Arnhem-Leeuwarden](#), Jan 2026).

The decisions that cannot be deferred this cycle

1. **Rank the five, in writing.** The queue is being ordered by statutory proximity rather than by strategic value, which is a choice made by not making one.
2. **Decide whether the reform is delivery or redesign.** The answer determines whether the organisation is in the room when the new system is specified.
3. **Treat the AI ceiling as a design constraint, not a delay.** The defence against industrialised fraud has to be built inside the limits, because the limits are not going to move first.

4. **Bank the cross-border information uplift before absorbing its burden.** DAC8 and DAC9 data have analytical value that is separable from the reporting load they arrive with.

Each is developed below, with a decision posture, in the four Strategic Implications.

Audience Snapshots

Four lenses on the same evidence base. Each card surfaces the one question this cycle puts to that reader.

BESTUUR / DG

Five programmes, one capacity pool, and no published ranking

The shift: Box 3 toward 2028 ([Meijburg & Co](#), May 2025), the reform agenda due at year end ([EY Netherlands](#), Feb 2026), the e-invoicing build toward 2030 ([RTC Suite](#), Oct 2025), fraud-defence rebuild, and AI Act compliance all draw on the same constrained change capacity.

The question to brief: Which of the five have we actually ranked against each other, and who outside this building knows the order?

CIO / IV

The modernisation is real, and it is slower than the plans built on top of it

The shift: Legacy systems were still 19.3% of the estate, with several phase-out projects behind schedule ([ICT Magazine](#), May 2025), while the administration's own plan puts fully automatic taxation after 2035 ([the Belastingdienst](#), Dec 2025).

The question to brief: Which commitments made this year assume a modernisation rate the portfolio has not yet demonstrated?

TOEZICHT & HANDHAVING

Your own use of AI is capped while the attacker's is not

The shift: The audit office found privacy risks in algorithmic selection still poorly managed ([the Algemene Rekenkamer](#), May 2025), and the EU framework tightens around high-risk public-sector systems ([the European Commission](#), undated), at the moment fraud is industrialising ([Sumsb](#), Nov 2025).

The question to brief: What does a defensible detection capability look like built entirely inside the current constraints, rather than one waiting for them to ease?

CFO / DOUANE

The information position improves and the reporting load rises together

The shift: DAC8 is live and transposed ([KPMG](#), Mar 2026) and DAC9 landed with the 2026 package ([KPMG](#), Dec 2025), on an administration already among Europe's busiest recipients ([CFE Tax Advisers Europe](#), Feb 2026).

The question to brief: What are we doing with the data we now receive, as distinct from what it costs us to receive it?

Themes

The cycle's signals are organised into four themes, ranked by impact on near-term decisions.

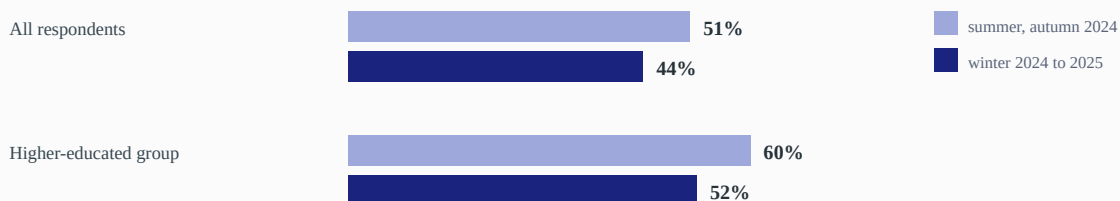
Immediate: changes the near-term plan, the structure or the proposition. **Near-Term:** changes position over the next twelve months. **Longer-Range:** a multi-year factor to track and revisit each cycle.

1. Trust recovery as the binding constraint

IMMEDIATE

Trust is recovering slowly while the operating environment for staff has hardened, and the two move together. Three vectors converge: the unresolved legacy of the childcare-benefits scandal, continuing scrutiny of algorithmic selection, and an anti-institutional movement that has changed how officials can safely work. Any further visible misstep resets the recovery clock at exactly the moment the organisation needs goodwill capital to absorb a large reform mandate. This is the binding constraint on every other theme in this brief, because it governs what the organisation is permitted to do rather than what it is able to do.

Reported trust in government, summer 2024 against winter 2024 to 2025



The group that was historically most positive fell furthest, closing its margin over the average.

Goodwill is the capital a reform mandate is spent from. It fell in both groups across a single winter.

- Reported trust in government fell from 51% to 44% between summer and autumn 2024 and the following winter. Among the higher-educated group, historically the most positive, it fell from 60% to 52%, closing a margin that had held for years ([the Sociaal en Cultureel Planbureau](#), Mar 2025).
- By the autumn instalment the framing had moved from confidence to maatschappelijk onbehagen, a settled sense that the country is heading the wrong way, read as the frame for the election run-up rather than as an episodic mood ([the Sociaal en Cultureel Planbureau](#), Oct 2025).
- The Algemene Rekenkamer found that the Belastingdienst and Dienst Toeslagen still do not manage privacy risks well in their use of algorithms, and framed it as a governance failure rather than a problem with the tools, pointing out that another executive agency runs the same class of instrument compliantly ([the Algemene Rekenkamer](#), May 2025). The underlying audit records a structural staffing shortfall and unreplaced legacy IT as what blocks simplification ([the Algemene Rekenkamer](#), May 2025).

- In January a court accepted that naming officials in cases involving the soevereinen movement would expose them to doxing and real danger, and allowed the Belastingdienst to withhold staff names. Anonymity is now legally grounded operating practice rather than a contingency ([the Gerechtshof Arnhem-Leeuwarden](#), Jan 2026).
- The AIVD's annual report, published five days before this brief, describes a compounding rather than episodic threat picture, made persistent by the destabilisation of the wider order ([the AIVD](#), Apr 2026).
- The administration's own answer to the legitimacy problem is disclosure: an algorithm register published on the argument that saying what each system does is what makes its use defensible ([the Belastingdienst algorithm register](#), May 2023).

Early indicators

- **WEAK SIGNAL** **Anonymity as an operating model, not an exception.** A court has now blessed a defensive posture. The second-order effect is on recruitment, on the willingness of staff to take enforcement roles, and on how an organisation explains itself publicly when its people cannot be named ([the Gerechtshof Arnhem-Leeuwarden](#), Jan 2026).

Counter-argument

Trust measures are volatile and a single winter is not a trend; the series itself is one publication read twice, not two independent readings. The audit finding is also a year old at the cycle date and may have been acted on without a public statement. The thesis weakens if the next Burgerperspectieven instalment shows the fall reversing, or if the audit office records the privacy findings as resolved.

Decision link: SI 1. Goodwill is the capital a reform mandate is spent from, so its level is a planning input, not a communications matter.

2. Three AI vectors converging at once

IMMEDIATE

Three distinct AI vectors arrive at the same moment. Taxpayers have begun treating generative AI as their first-line adviser. Fraudsters are industrialising. And the administration's own ceiling on AI use is rising, under post-scandal scrutiny at home and a new regulatory regime from Europe. The awkwardness is structural rather than accidental: the natural defence against automated attack is more automated detection, which is exactly the move the regulatory regime is narrowing.

- Around 64% of businesses now consult public AI chatbots before asking their accountant. The survey is UK based and the Dutch direction of travel reads consistent rather than proven ([Accountant.nl](#), Oct 2025).

- The EU framework makes trustworthy AI the condition of market access rather than merely restricting it, and the obligations on high-risk public-sector systems fall inside this planning window ([the European Commission](#), undated). The Act applies in phases rather than at a single moment, which decides what has already bitten and what can still be prepared for ([Kennedys Law](#), undated).
- Agentic systems break the framework's assumptions about traceability and human oversight: without an audit trail and a fast way to revoke an agent's authority, lawful operation cannot be demonstrated ([AI News](#), Apr 2026).
- Fraud's composition is shifting even where its headline rate is flat, from single-step deception toward multi-step and agentic schemes ([Sumsb](#), Nov 2025), with vendors forecasting agentic attack as the leading 2026 threat ([Experian](#), Jan 2026) ([Sardine.ai](#), Feb 2026). All three are commercially interested and are treated here as one argument, not three.
- Putting tax material through public AI platforms now carries a privilege risk after a US ruling that exchanges with a public AI tool were not protected, which makes workflow choice a legal question rather than a productivity one ([Morgan Lewis](#), Mar 2026).
- The Dutch regulator's position is that algorithmic risk should be tracked and published as a recurring public picture rather than handled case by case ([the Autoriteit Persoonsgegevens](#), undated).

Early indicators

- **WEAK SIGNAL** **The adviser layer is being disintermediated before the administration is.** If most businesses ask a chatbot first, the quality of the answer they receive becomes a compliance variable the administration does not control and cannot see ([Accountant.nl](#), Oct 2025).

Counter-argument

The regulatory ceiling may be lower in the headlines than in practice: phasing and public-interest provisions give more room than a strict reading implies, and the fraud case rests on interested vendors forecasting a year that had barely started. The honest position is that the direction is credible and the magnitude is not evidenced. The thesis weakens if a supervisory instrument gives public-authority enforcement systems explicit room, or if independent, non-vendor data on agentic fraud fails to materialise.

Decision link: SI 3. Build the detection capability that is defensible inside the current constraints rather than one that assumes they ease.

3. Cross-border harmonisation as both opportunity and operational squeeze

NEAR-TERM

The 2026 wave of European instruments gives the administration its strongest information position in a decade and its heaviest concurrent reporting load, and these are the same wave rather than two competing ones. The question this theme puts is not whether to absorb the burden but whether the analytical value of the incoming data is being extracted at all, or whether it is being received, stored and left.

- DAC8 extends automatic exchange to crypto-assets, which the Commission frames as closing a gap national authorities cannot close alone ([the European Commission](#), undated). The Dutch implementing bill cleared the lower house in March and bites retroactively from the start of 2026, so obligations run ahead of final enactment ([KPMG](#), Mar 2026).
- The 2026 package completed passage on schedule carrying DAC9 transposition and Pillar Two amendment, making both settled law rather than pending proposals ([KPMG](#), Dec 2025).
- The Commission's agenda has turned toward simplification, with a package reopening fifteen existing directives ([Accountancy Europe](#), Feb 2026), and the omnibus is consolidation rather than a new front: a review of how existing rules operate together ([Grant Thornton](#), Mar 2026).
- The advisers' own submissions argue the DAC has fragmented across eight amendments into an incoherent compliance stack that the recast should consolidate ([CFE Tax Advisers Europe](#), Feb 2026), and that simplification is only real if it removes duplication with Pillar Two rather than weakening safeguards ([CFE Tax Advisers Europe](#), Mar 2026).
- Industry makes the same argument from the other side: overlapping DAC7, CESOP and ViDA obligations have produced a sharp rise in compliance cost ([the European Tech Alliance](#), Feb 2026).
- Portfolio note, because it bears on who the administration negotiates with: the Commissioner carrying taxation holds it as a secondary responsibility alongside climate and clean growth, not as his portfolio ([the European Commission](#), undated).

Counter-argument

An information uplift is only an uplift if it is used, and nothing in this evidence base demonstrates analytical capacity to exploit DAC8 and DAC9 data rather than merely receive it. It is equally arguable that the simplification agenda will reduce the load before the burden becomes binding. The thesis weakens if the recast lands early and materially, or if the administration publishes a concrete analytical use for the new data flows.

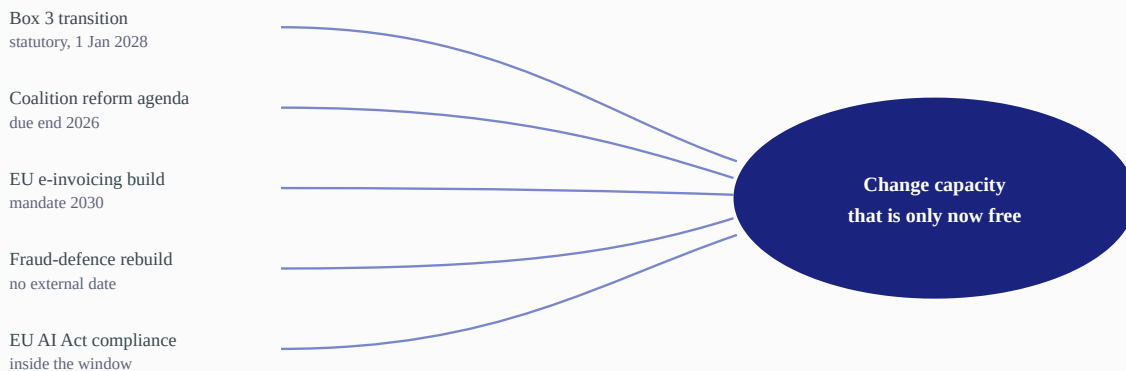
Decision link: SI 4. Separate the value of the data from the cost of receiving it, and fund the first.

4. The reform window meets the capacity that has to deliver it

LONGER-RANGE

A coalition with a reform mandate is, on the face of it, a once-in-a-generation chance to redesign the citizen-state tax interaction toward something embedded and seamless rather than periodic and adversarial. That reading is the optimistic one and this brief does not adopt it. On the evidence assembled here the window is real and the capacity to use it is not yet demonstrated, and the sources closest to the organisation are the most cautious of all.

Five programmes, one pool of change capacity



Only one of the five has no external date. Where a queue is not ranked explicitly, statutory proximity ranks it.

- The coalition commits to a fundamental overhaul of income tax, benefits and social security with the reform agenda due at the end of 2026, and a new Box 3 regime targeted at 1 January 2028 ([EY Netherlands](#), Feb 2026) ([Meijburg & Co](#), May 2025).
- The direction of travel internationally is real: comparative data across tax administrations shows prefilling, embedded payment and digital identity scaling ([OECD](#), Nov 2025), and administrations describing themselves as becoming technology-led institutions ([the OECD](#), undated).
- But the administration's own published plan puts fully automatic taxation **after 2035**, which is two planning horizons beyond the reform agenda it is said to enable ([the Belastingdienst](#), Dec 2025).
- And the estate has not yet moved far enough to carry it. Legacy systems stood at 19.3% with several phase-out projects behind their planned progress ([ICT Magazine](#), May 2025).
- And the mandate itself is weaker than the word suggests. The measures come from a minority coalition that lacks the parliamentary majority to enact them, which is the reading the analysis stresses rather than a caveat added to it ([KPMG](#), Feb 2026).
- The e-invoicing infrastructure that would operationalise an embedded model is targeted at July 2030, well outside the coalition's own term ([RTC Suite](#), Oct 2025).

Early indicators

- **WEAK SIGNAL** The design table and the delivery table are being allocated now. Whether the administration is treated as the designer of a new operating model or the deliverer of someone else's policy is being settled by where capacity is pointed this year, not by the reform agenda's eventual text ([EY Netherlands](#), Feb 2026).

Counter-argument

The case for the optimistic reading is that windows like this are rare and that waiting for demonstrated capacity guarantees the window closes unused: an organisation that will only commit once its estate is ready will never commit. That argument has force, and it is the reason this theme is graded Longer-Range rather than dismissed. But the three sources closest to the work, the administration's own plan, the state of its legacy estate, and the arithmetic of a minority coalition, all point the same way, and a thesis whose nearest evidence contradicts it should be held lightly. The thesis strengthens if the reform agenda arrives with a funded operating-model workstream and a date earlier than 2035 attached to it.

Decision link: SI 2. Decide whether this is policy delivery or operating-model redesign, because the two need different people and a different budget.

Strategic Implications

Four implications, each carrying a decision posture. Two are decisions this cycle rather than next, because in both cases the default is being chosen now by not choosing.

SI 1: Rank the five competing programmes in writing, and publish what the losers do not get

Box 3 toward 2028 ([Meijburg & Co](#), May 2025), the reform agenda due at year end ([EY Netherlands](#), Feb 2026), the e-invoicing build toward 2030 ([RTC Suite](#), Oct 2025), the fraud-defence rebuild and AI Act compliance all draw on the same constrained change capacity. Four of the five carry an external date and one does not, which means the undated one loses by default whatever its strategic value. The lever is prioritisation with disclosure: an explicit ranking costs political capital once, while an implicit one costs delivery credibility every time a date slips and the reason cannot be given.

Action: Publish an internal ranking of the five with what each of the lower-ranked will not receive, and take the ranking to the department rather than absorbing the conflict inside delivery plans.

DECIDE

Draws on Themes 1 and 4

SI 2: Settle whether the reform is policy delivery or operating-model redesign

The two readings need different people, a different budget and a different seat. The optimistic case is that the window is rare and will not wait ([OECD](#), Nov 2025). The evidence closest to the work is more cautious: the administration's own plan dates automatic taxation after 2035 ([the Belastingdienst](#), Dec 2025), the legacy estate stood at 19.3% ([ICT Magazine](#), May 2025), and the coalition lacks the majority to enact its own measures ([KPMG](#), Feb 2026). A decision taken explicitly can be a modest one. A decision taken by default will be delivery, because delivery is what arrives with a date attached.

Action: Name which of the two the organisation is pursuing, and if it is redesign, fund a workstream with a date earlier than 2035 against it.

DECIDE

Draws on Theme 4

SI 3: Build the detection capability that is defensible inside the current constraints

The constraints are not going to ease first. The audit office has the privacy management of algorithmic selection open ([the Algemene Rekenkamer](#), May 2025), the European framework tightens around high-risk public-sector systems ([the European Commission](#), undated), and the phasing decides what has already bitten ([Kennedys Law](#), undated). Meanwhile fraud's composition is shifting toward multi-step and agentic schemes ([Sumsb](#), Nov 2025). Waiting for room is a strategy that assumes someone else will create it.

Action: Specify the detection capability that would survive the strictest plausible reading of the rules, and build that, treating any later easing as upside rather than as the plan.

PREPARE

Draws on Themes 1 and 2

SI 4: Separate the value of the incoming data from the cost of receiving it

DAC8 is live and transposed ([KPMG](#), Mar 2026), DAC9 landed with the 2026 package ([KPMG](#), Dec 2025), and the recast may thin the stack later ([CFE Tax Advisers Europe](#), Feb 2026). Nothing in this cycle's evidence shows what the administration intends to do analytically with what it now receives. An information position that is only ever received is a cost centre wearing the language of an advantage.

Action: Name one analytical use for DAC8 or DAC9 data that would not have been possible a year ago, fund it separately from the reporting build, and report on it.

PREPARE

Draws on Theme 3

Scenario Matrix

Two variables drive the next eighteen months. Horizontally, whether the reform mandate converts into decisions or dissipates in a minority parliament. Vertically, whether change capacity is actively ranked or left to be allocated by whichever deadline is nearest.

DECISION SUPPLY

Small mandate, used well

The reform agenda thins in a minority parliament ([KPMG](#), Feb 2026), but the queue is ranked explicitly and the organisation spends the period retiring legacy and banking the cross-border data position. Unglamorous, and the best available preparation for whatever window opens next.

Early indicators: A published ranking of the five programmes; legacy share falling faster than its recent rate; a named analytical use for DAC8 data.

The window is used

The reform agenda arrives with decisions attached and the organisation has already said what it will not do, so it can take the design seat rather than the delivery seat. This is the only quadrant in which an embedded service model becomes more than an aspiration dated after 2035 ([the Belastingdienst](#), Dec 2025).

Early indicators: A funded operating-model workstream inside the reform agenda; Belastingdienst named in the design phase rather than consulted on feasibility; a date earlier than 2035 attached to automatic taxation.

Statutory proximity decides

The most likely continuation of the present state. Box 3's 2028 date pulls capacity because it is nearest ([Meijburg & Co](#), May 2025), the fraud-defence rebuild loses because it has no statutory date, and the e-invoicing build is discovered late ([RTC Suite](#), Oct 2025). Nobody chooses this and everybody can explain it.

Early indicators: No published ranking; the fraud-defence rebuild

MANDATE DISSIPATES, CAPACITY UNRA
deferred without a decision note; e-invoicing treated as a 2029 problem.

A mandate larger than the machine

The reform agenda lands in full against an estate still carrying 19.3% legacy ([ICT Magazine](#), May 2025) and a trust position that has not recovered ([the Sociaal en Cultureel Planbureau](#), Mar 2025). Delivery is attempted at a rate the organisation has not demonstrated, which is the precondition that produced the last crisis.

Early indicators: Reform milestones

MANDATE CONVERTS, CAPACITY UNRANKED
set without a published

uitvoeringstoets; recruitment targets rising faster than delivered capacity; legacy retirement slipping while new build accelerates.

What We Are Not Planning For

THREAT HORIZON

We are not planning for a cyber or quantum discontinuity in this window

Both are real and both are covered in the organisation's own threat material. Neither is differentiated by external scanning at this horizon, and including them would have blurred four mechanism-distinct themes into five overlapping ones. The threat picture this brief does carry is the anti-institutional one, which is already operational rather than prospective ([the AIVD](#), Apr 2026).

↺ **Reinstated if** a cryptographically relevant quantum milestone is announced, or a peer administration suffers a confidentiality breach at scale.

WORKFORCE

We are not planning for workforce demographics as a strategic variable this cycle

Ageing and succession are operationally important and are not, at a two to five year horizon, what decides the outcomes in this brief. Capacity here means the safe rate of system change, not headcount, and the audit evidence points at the estate rather than at the establishment ([the Algemene Rekenkamer](#), May 2025).

↺ **Reinstated if** attrition in the IV function rises materially, or the anonymity posture begins to show in recruitment ([the Gerechtshof Arnhem-Leeuwarden](#), Jan 2026).

REGULATORY REVERSAL

We are not planning for the European AI rules being loosened for public authorities

The regime is built on making trustworthy AI the condition of market access rather than on restricting it, and its obligations arrive in phases already under way ([the European Commission](#), undated) ([Kennedys Law](#), undated). Planning on relief would mean building a detection capability that only works if someone else changes their mind.

↺ **Reinstated if** a formal transitional instrument reaches public-authority enforcement systems, or national guidance settles materially below the strictest reading.

Questions For The Next Strategy Meeting

Five questions this cycle's evidence should put on the agenda.

- 01 Of the five programmes competing for change capacity, which have we ranked against each other, and would anyone outside this building be able to name the order?
- 02 Our own plan dates fully automatic taxation to after 2035 ([the Belastingdienst](#), Dec 2025) while the reform agenda is due this year. Which of those two horizons are our commitments actually written against?
- 03 If the European AI rules never loosened, what in our detection roadmap would change? If the answer is nothing, what is that assumption doing in the roadmap ([the European Commission](#), undated)?
- 04 We will receive materially more cross-border data this year ([KPMG](#), Mar 2026). Name one analytical question we can now answer that we could not answer last year.

05 Trust fell seven points across one winter, and furthest among the group that was most positive (the Sociaal en Cultureel Planbureau, Mar 2025). What in the next twelve months is most likely to move it again, and is anyone accountable for that number?

Source Confidence Register

This briefing draws on 33 verified sources, gathered under a six-month window (publications from March 2026 onward), with 4 structural anchors outside it. 33 are in a language other than English and were read in the original, because on this topic the translated version arrives late and loses the numbers.

Source tiers: **Tier 1**, governments, parliaments, regulators, courts and intergovernmental bodies. **Tier 2**, national audit offices, think-tanks, academic institutes and major professional firms. **Tier 3**, quality journalism and specialist trade press. **Tier 4**, vendor and practitioner sources, used only as directional corroboration. This cycle uses no Tier 4 source.

Theme 1: Trust recovery as the binding constraint

Source	Tier	Date	Key claim used
Algemene Rekenkamer (in Dutch)	Tier 1	May 2025	Belastingdienst and Dienst Toeslagen still do not adequately manage privacy risks for citizens in their use of algorithms; the Algemene Rekenkamer expects the minister to ensure in 2025 that risks for the responsible use of risk-prediction algorithms are better managed; risks remain insufficiently controlled.
Sociaal en Cultureel Planbureau (SCP) (in Dutch)	Tier 1	Mar 2025	Trust in the Dutch government fell from 51% in summer/autumn 2024 to 44% in winter 2024/2025; trust among hbo/wo-educated Dutch fell from 60% to 52%, eliminating the historical positive gap with vmbo-educated citizens; 57% of Dutch say the country is going the wrong way; 30% want harder action against the government, 18% would overthrow the system.

Source	Tier	Date	Key claim used
Sociaal en Cultureel Planbureau (SCP) <i>(in Dutch)</i>	Tier 1	Oct 2025	Most recent quarterly Dutch citizen-perspective tracking; tracks the trajectory of political trust, social cohesion, and views on government competence into late 2025. Updates the long-running SCP series referenced inside the Belastingdienst's own 2025 Trendalert.
AIVD (Algemene Inlichtingen- en Veiligheidsdienst) <i>(in Dutch)</i>	Tier 1	Apr 2026	Published 23 April 2026, five days before this report. Confirms anti-institutional extremists (soevereinen) remain active; Russian state actors conducted cyberattacks targeting Signal and WhatsApp accounts of Dutch civil servants and military personnel; LAUNDRY BEAR cyber-actor compromised Dutch police staff contact data; AIVD director frames the threat picture as the most serious in 80 years.
Belastingdienst / Algoritmeregister <i>(in Dutch)</i>	Tier 1	May 2023	Ministry of Finance has registered 98 algorithms in the Algoritmeregister; Belastingdienst has 84 algorithms in category B, of which 35 are now published. Includes high-impact algorithms such as Selectiemodule Inkomensheffing (IH) and Risicotool Aanvullingen (RTA), and the OB Carrouselfraude signal model.
Gerechtshof Arnhem-Leeuwarden <i>(in Dutch)</i>	Tier 3	Jan 2026	Court of Appeal ruled that the Belastingdienst's request to keep its staff names confidential in soevereinen cases is justified given the documented threat profile, citing AIVD's fenomeenanalyse on the soevereinenbeweging. Belastingdienst now operates anonymously (under reference number, via PO boxes) in soevereinen cases.
Algemene Rekenkamer <i>(in Dutch)</i>	Tier 1	May 2025	Annual accountability examination of the Ministry of Finance for FY2024; flags continuing privacy issues with Belastingdienst and Dienst Toeslagen algorithms and identifies the ministerial oversight expectations for 2025.

Theme 2: Three AI vectors converging at once

Source	Tier	Date	Key claim used
European Commission	Tier 1	Evergreen	EU AI Act in force from 1 August 2024; bans on prohibited practices effective 4 February 2025; high-risk system obligations effective 2 August 2026 (conformity assessments, technical documentation, CE marking, EU database registration); legacy public-sector high-risk systems must be brought into compliance or retired by 2 August 2030, extended grandfathering provision recognises public-sector procurement complexity.
Kennedys Law	Tier 2	Evergreen	Deployers of high-risk AI must retain system logs, comply with transparency obligations toward affected individuals, and where applicable conduct fundamental-rights impact assessments before deployment, particularly in public-sector decision-making. Implementing a compliant risk-management system, data-governance review, technical documentation and human-oversight training cannot be done in weeks.
Sumsub	Tier 2	Nov 2025	Identity-fraud schemes shifted from single-step deepfakes in 2024 to complex multi-step agentic-AI schemes in 2025; agentic AI fraud expected to surge in 2026, with autonomous agents managing synthetic profiles through multi-month maturation cycles, programmatically building credit history, and reusing/recombining stolen identity elements at scale.
Experian plc	Tier 2	Jan 2026	Experian's 2026 forecast: agentic AI is the dominant new fraud vector across financial services; deepfake job-candidate fraud has scaled rapidly; Europe's uneven KYC enforcement enables cross-border movement of synthetic-identity-funded transactions with minimal friction.

Source	Tier	Date	Key claim used
Accountant.nl (in Dutch)	Tier 2	Oct 2025	UK survey reports 64% of businesses now consult public AI chatbots (e.g. ChatGPT) for advice before they ask their accountant. Direction of travel reads consistent in NL accountant-press; signals the shift in the first-line-of-tax-advice market that Belastingdienst must factor into its service-design and information-positioning strategy.
Morgan Lewis	Tier 2	Mar 2026	On 10 February 2026, Judge Jed Rakoff ruled that a defendant's communications with a publicly available AI platform (ChatGPT) were not protected by attorney-client privilege or work-product doctrine, one of the first US rulings on privilege claims involving generative AI in tax workflows. Material precedent for any tax authority where taxpayer-AI interactions become evidentiary.
ArtificialIntelligence-News	Tier 2	Apr 2026	Agentic AI systems do not map cleanly onto the EU AI Act's deployer / provider / user categories; oversight regimes designed for static AI systems struggle with agents that plan, execute and adapt autonomously. New regulatory questions on accountability when an agent acts on a user's behalf at scale.
Autoriteit Persoonsgegevens	Tier 1	Evergreen	Standing AP page tracking Dutch algorithmic-risk developments; calls out three top concerns for 2026, AI in recruitment and selection growing rapidly with major risks, transparency and explainability falling short, AI Verordening preparation lagging.
Sardine.ai	Tier 3	Feb 2026	Documents seven agentic-AI fraud attack types observed live in 2026, including identity-farm operations, automated account-opening at scale, multi-party invoice manipulation, and synthetic-identity maturation cycles. 90% of financial-crime professionals report measurable increases in AI-driven attacks.

Theme 3: Cross-border harmonisation as both opportunity and operational squeeze

Source	Tier	Date	Key claim used
European Commission	Tier 1	Evergreen	DAC8 entered into force on 13 November 2023; transposition deadline 31 December 2025; effective for crypto-asset service providers from 1 January 2026, crypto-asset service providers must collect data on reportable transactions for first reporting in 2027. Builds on OECD Crypto-Asset Reporting Framework (CARF).
European Commission	Tier 1	Evergreen	Hoekstra holds taxation portfolio; 2026 priorities are tobacco taxation, simplification, the DAC, and Energy Taxation Directive; new tax omnibus due Q2 2026 to reduce compliance burdens and cut duplicate administrative requirements; assessing enhanced cooperation route for DEBRA and similar proposals where unanimity blocks adoption.
KPMG (TaxNewsFlash)	Tier 2	Dec 2025	Dutch 2026 Tax Plan adopted; includes implementation of latest OECD Administrative Guidelines into the Minimum Tax Act 2024 (Pillar Two); implements DAC9; coordinated with Hoekstra's tax-omnibus simplification track.
KPMG (TaxNewsFlash)	Tier 2	Mar 2026	Lower house of Dutch Parliament approved the bill adopting DAC8 in March 2026; Netherlands has enacted legislation implementing EU DAC8 and OECD CARF rules; effective retroactively from 1 January 2026 with first reporting obligations in 2027.
Accountancy Europe	Tier 2	Feb 2026	Pan-European accountancy-profession update on EU tax policy: tax omnibus due Q2 2026; tax simplification proposals due June 2026; DAC9 implementation across Member States; ViDA implementation timetable consolidating; BEFIT under continued negotiation.

Source	Tier	Date	Key claim used
CFE Tax Advisers Europe	Tier 2	Mar 2026	Tax-adviser profession's formal response to the omnibus consultation: identifies fragmentation and inconsistency in EU direct-tax framework as the binding problem; recommends aligning CFC rules with global minimum tax framework, harmonising GAAR wording across Member States, limiting national implementation options.
CFE Tax Advisers Europe	Tier 2	Feb 2026	CFE position on DAC recast, accumulated DAC1 through DAC9 has produced overlapping reporting regimes; recast should consolidate, eliminate duplicates, and clarify the boundary between automatic information exchange and on-request cooperation. Material because the Belastingdienst is one of the busiest DAC-receiving administrations.
Grant Thornton	Tier 2	Mar 2026	Detailed Dutch tax-practitioner analysis of the proposed tax omnibus changes: practical scope, transposition timeline, areas of coordination with the broader CSRD-omnibus simplification package, and Member State implementation discretion.
European Tech Alliance (EUTA)	Tier 3	Feb 2026	Industry-coalition position: the omnibus must avoid further compliance fragmentation; calls for digital-first reporting standards aligned with ViDA; warns that uncoordinated DAC8/DAC9/Pillar Two reporting will create duplicate data flows that improve neither tax administration nor taxpayer service.

Theme 4: The reform window meets the capacity that has to deliver it

Source	Tier	Date	Key claim used
OECD	Tier 1	Nov 2025	Comparative international benchmark across 50+ tax administrations; 81-100% of individuals in two-thirds of jurisdictions use digital identity to access tax services; multifactor authentication and mobile apps overtaking password-based authentication; embedded payment facilities scaling; documents Belastingdienst position relative to peers across digital service maturity.
OECD Blog	Tier 2	Evergreen	OECD blog framing of the Tax Administration 3.0 vision in operational terms: taxation moves from 'a thing taxpayers do' to 'a thing that happens'; tax administration's role shifts from compliance enforcement to service design and rule architecture.
EY Netherlands	Tier 2	Feb 2026	D66-VVD-CDA minority coalition agreement published 30 January 2026; commits to a fundamental overhaul of income tax, allowances (toeslagen), social security; reform agenda with specific milestones due end of 2026; coalition wants to align definitions and conditions of tax, social security and allowances; gradually phase out income-dependent schemes starting with tax credits; preserve corporate-tax stability (innovation box, WBSO, participation exemption, expat regime).
KPMG (TaxNewsFlash)	Tier 2	Feb 2026	Detailed sell-side analysis of the Jetten coalition's proposed tax measures: 66 seats in lower house, no automatic majority for measures; reform agenda will require cross-bench negotiation on specific bills; Box 3 transition to the new actual-return regime targeted 1 January 2028; income tax / toeslagen overhaul on a four-year timeline.

Source	Tier	Date	Key claim used
Belastingdienst (<i>in Dutch</i>)	Tier 1	Dec 2025	Belastingdienst Jaarplan 2026: four priorities (verbinden met de samenleving, basis op orde, continu verbeteren dienstverlening/toezicht/opsporing, werken met plezier en vakmanschap); proactive communication and customisation via VanZelfGoed and KeuzeDigitaal programmes; signaalmanagement strengthening; staatssecretaris confirms 'deel ICT-systemen kan vanaf 2026 nieuw beleid aan'; partial capacity recovery.
ICT Magazine NL (<i>in Dutch</i>)	Tier 2	May 2025	Belastingdienst IT estate is 19.3% legacy in 2024, down from 20% in 2023; IV-day capacity for IT projects rose to 668,000 with 664,000 realised; almost half of FY24 IV-days went to modernisation of outdated ICT; modernisation projected to be largely complete by end-2026, some chains continuing to 2027; 7 of 9 Cool:Gen phase-out projects on schedule.
RTC Suite / VATupdate	Tier 3	Oct 2025	EY-prepared report submitted to Dutch Parliament 10 March 2026 on ViDA implementation: cross-border B2B e-invoicing and near-real-time digital reporting from 1 July 2030 mandatory; Netherlands considering extending to all domestic B2B; technical model uses EN 16931 structured e-invoices, Peppol-style exchange, near-real-time reporting layer; clarity expected summer 2026, draft bill consultation Q4 2026, legislation mid-2028, domestic e-invoicing January 2030.

Source	Tier	Date	Key claim used
Meijburg & Co (KPMG)	Tier 2	May 2025	On 12 February 2026 the Lower House approved the new Box 3 regime for actual-return taxation; new regime takes effect 1 January 2028 (postponed from 2026, then 2027); two parallel regimes, vermogensaanwasbelasting (capital growth) for most assets and vermogenswinstbelasting (capital gains) for real estate and certain unlisted shares in startups; WOZ value as at 1 January 2028 to be used for homes; Upper House debate this spring is the binding step.

Claim-fidelity self-disclosure

This edition was first published on 28 April 2026. It is re-issued here in the current format. The analysis is unchanged except in one respect, recorded below. What has changed substantially is the source base, because every source was re-opened on 16 September 2026 and the register now carries per-source date evidence the original capture did not have.

Seven sources were dropped because they could no longer be read

A practice-guide chapter has been withdrawn by its publisher and now serves only a removal notice. Two specialist-press items and a regulator's report return HTTP 403 to any automated request. An OECD paper and a Dutch government file are blocked by robots rules. And one citation pointed at a parliamentary search interface rather than a document: it has no publication date, it shows today's results rather than March's, and the specific motion recorded against it could not be located, so the citation could not be repaired. Forty sources became thirty-three. Nothing was substituted in their place, because a replacement would be evidence this edition never saw.

Two claims have been removed with them

April reported the data protection authority's AI Impact Barometer standing at four red indicators, doubled in six months, and a Tweede Kamer motion of 10 March 2026 on access to documents underlying intent assessments. Both appeared in the Executive Synthesis. The only sources for either are among those dropped, so both are absent here rather than restated on the strength of a citation that can no longer be opened.

Six recorded dates were impossible and have been corrected

In six cases the date recorded against a source preceded that source's own publication. One item was recorded twelve days before it existed; another was recorded on the date the coalition agreement was presented rather than the date the analysis of it was published, which suggests the original capture sometimes logged the event rather than the source. Every date in the register is now the date printed on the page. Six pages carry no printed date at all and are recorded as undated rather than assigned a date inferred from a web address.

Three sources were re-graded

Two vendor sources moved from Tier 2 to Tier 3, because a firm selling fraud prevention arguing that incumbent detection fails is commercially interested, as is a compliance vendor arguing for a mandate ([Sardine.ai](#), Feb 2026) ([RTC Suite](#), Oct 2025). The court ruling moved from Tier 1 to Tier 3 because it is cited from a commercial aggregator rather than from the court ([the Gerechtshof Arnhem-Leeuwarden](#), Jan 2026); the authoritative text sits under the same case number at the national judiciary site, which could not be machine-verified because that site serves only an application shell.

The evidence base is narrower than thirty-three suggests

The audit office's news item and its underlying report are one publication counted twice ([the Algemene Rekenkamer](#), May 2025) ([the Algemene Rekenkamer](#), May 2025), and the two citizen-perspective instalments are successive editions of a single series ([the Sociaal en Cultureel Planbureau](#), Mar 2025) ([the Sociaal en Cultureel Planbureau](#), Oct 2025). Three fraud sources are commercially interested and make one argument between them ([Sumsb](#), Nov 2025) ([Experian](#), Jan 2026) ([Sardine.ai](#), Feb 2026). We have said so where each is used rather than letting the count imply breadth the set does not have.

The one change to the analysis

Theme 4's counter-argument is materially stronger than in April. Three of its eight surviving sources argue against its own thesis: the administration's published plan dates fully automatic taxation to after 2035 ([the Belastingdienst](#), Dec 2025), its legacy estate stood at 19.3% with phase-out projects behind schedule ([ICT Magazine](#), May 2025), and the coalition is a minority without the votes to enact its measures ([KPMG](#), Feb 2026). April carried these sources and framed the theme optimistically anyway. Re-read today, the evidence does not support that framing, and the theme has been re-graded to Longer-Range with the tension stated rather than smoothed. No other theme's reading was altered.

This Decision Intelligence briefing is the quarterly synthesis of a Shaping Tomorrow intelligence cycle on the **Belastingdienst**. It sits on top of weekly Signal Scans that identify emerging developments and weak signals, and monthly Change Trackers that assess what is materially shifting in momentum. Cycles may also close with Action Triggers, an end-of-cycle synthesis that reads across all four formats and surfaces patterns no single deliverable carries on its own. Continuous intelligence on this topic is available as a Single-Topic or Multi-Topic programme.

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